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Ekphrasis ancient and modern: the invention of a genre[1]

RUTH WEBB

1 – This article contains material presented at a Round Table on *Ekphrasis* at the Université de Paris-Nanterre in March 1994. An expanded version will form part of a book currently in progress on *ekphrasis* in ancient and Byzantine rhetoric.

In contemporary critical terminology 'ekphrasis' has come to be firmly associated with the subject of this journal: word and image. Mention 'ekphrasis' to an art historian, literary critic or classicist, and the examples that spring to mind are likely to include the Homeric Shield of Achilles and its many literary imitations, the rhetorical and allegorical descriptions of paintings written by later Greek prose authors, like Lucian and the Elder and Younger Philostratos or, from more recent periods of Western literary history, John Keats' meditation on his tantalisingly still and silent Grecian Urn. This 'genre', or 'trope', of *ekphrasis* evokes a network of interlocking questions and interests, from the positivist pursuit of lost monuments described in ancient and medieval *ekphrasis* to the poststructuralist fascination with a textual fragment which declares itself to be pure artifice, the representation of representation.

Today, numerous publications have ensured that the term is firmly attached to issues of word and image.[2] By a sort of etymological magic, the Greek word is even seen to bear its meaning inscribed within it. Jean Hagstrum defended his idiosyncratic use of the term to designate texts in which the work of art 'speaks out,' by the use of etymology, translating 'ekphrasis' as a speaking (*phrazo*) out (*ek*), while for Philippe Hamon the preposition, *ek*, conveys the separable nature of these descriptions of art objects which exemplify the nature of description as a detachable fragment, distinct from its narrative frame.[3] (A more flexible etymology, which the critic can interpret at will, is the one which simply translates the term as 'a telling, a speaking out.'[4])

But when one looks more closely at the range of definitions on offer, one is inevitably struck by a degree of divergence strangely at odds with the belief in a quasi-immanent meaning suggested both by the modern etymologies and the many assertions of what 'ekphrasis is' to be found in the burgeoning literature.[5] The confidence of all these assertions is striking, too striking perhaps, for it masks some fundamental (but rarely stated) disagreements about the nature of *ekphrasis*.[6] For some, *ekphrasis* includes descriptions of non-representational arts, for others it is the 'verbal representation of visual representation.'[7] On the one hand *ekphrasis* is a 'classic genre' with its roots deep in antiquity, on the other scholars do not agree about which works should be included in this genre: do descriptions of buildings count? Does 'description' include a catalogue entry?[8] As each new study redefines the term to fit the critic's selection of works and to accommodate a particular critical stance, one is tempted to ask whether there is in fact a single phenomenon that can usefully be called 'ekphrasis.'

2 – For example, Murray Krieger, *Ekphrasis: The Illusion of the Natural Sign* (Baltimore, 1991); James A. W. Heffernan, *Museum of Words: The Poetics of Ekphrasis from Homer to Ashbery* (Chicago, 1993); Grant F. Scott, *The Sculpted Word: Keats, Ekphrasis, and the Visual Arts* (Hanover, 1995); Peter Wagner (ed.), *Icons – Texts – Iconotexts: Essays on Ekphrasis and Intermediality* (Berlin, 1996).

3 – Jean Hagstrum, *The Sister Arts: The Tradition of Literary Pictorialism in English Poetry from Dryden to Gray* (Chicago, 1958), p. 18, n. 34; Philippe Hamon, *La description littéraire: de l'antiquité à Roland Barthes* (Paris, 1991), p. 8.

4 – Scott, *Sculpted Word*, p. 1.

5 – For example, W. Steiner, *The Colors of Rhetoric: Problems in the Relation Between Modern Literature and Painting* (Chicago, 1982), p. 41: 'The technical term for this is *ekphrasis*, the concentration of action in a single moment of energy . . .'; Heffernan, *Museum of Words*, p. 3 cited below; Stephen Bann, *The True Vine: On Visual Representation and the Western Tradition* (Cambridge, 1989), p. 28: '*Ekphrasis* as a genre of writing is dependent first all on the risky presumption that the visual work of art can be translated into terms of verbal discourse . . ..'

6 – The problem has also been pointed out by Raymond A. Macdonald in a Review Essay of Kreiger, *Ekphrasis*, in *Word & Image*, (1993), pp. 81–6.

7 – Heffernan, IX/1 *Museum of Words*, p. 3.

8 – Scott, *Sculpted Word*, p. 1.

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Appeal to the testimony of antiquity might then seem like a reasonable step. *Ekphrasis*, after all, is an ancient term and the practice of describing works of art goes back to Homer. But, as anyone who has taken this step from the modern to the ancient definition knows only too well, the ancient sources only complicate the question. The rhetorical handbooks offer a definition, but not the one expected. As is well known, 'ekphrasis' in antiquity had a far wider range of meaning than it does in modern criticism. As far as the rhetoricians were concerned, *ekphrasis* could be a description of a person, a place, even a battle, as well as of a painting or sculpture. And even though certain highly polished and sophisticated descriptions of paintings or artifacts, like Philostratos' *Imagines*, or the Shield of Achilles, were classified as 'ekphraseis' in antiquity, the technical writers on *ekphrasis* hardly evoke discussions of the visual arts, or the special questions raised by their translation into a verbal medium.

Most studies on *ekphrasis* begin with a nod in the direction of the original meaning of the term, and modern scholars have accounted for this discrepancy in various ways. One strategy is simply to dismiss the ancient rhetoricians: their definitions are too vague and broad to be useful; they are merely talking about a general type of description that does not merit further attention.[9] This strategy has the advantage of leaving the critics free to propose what they see as a more useful definition for the immediate purpose. On occasion they even correct the ancient sources. Roland Barthes, for example, seems to have assumed that the rhetoricians had carelessly forgotten to mention works of art when he added this category to his, otherwise accurate, account of ancient ekphrasis.[10] Several critics who, like Barthes, have first-hand familiarity with the ancient rhetorical sources simply ignore the discrepancy, conflating the ancient and modern definitions into one. Thus George Kennedy slips seamlessly from ancient to modern *ekphrasis* when he gives an entirely accurate account of *ekphrasis* as defined by Aphthonios in the fourth century CE (in which there is no mention of works of art) followed immediately by a brief survey of descriptions of works of art in ancient oratory.[11] Yet another strategy is to claim that the restricted modern meaning does in fact have ancient authority, that the meaning changed over the first centuries CE and that already in Late Antiquity 'ekphrasis narrows its focus and becomes a specialized genre devoted to objets d'art.'[12]

Should we worry about such a cavalier treatment of an ancient term? It is after all indisputable that there is a group of texts, starting with the inevitable Shield of Achilles, that have works of art as their subject-matter and which, as a group, raise a range of important questions about verbal and visual representation. Does it really matter whether a few obscure rhetoricians living in some corner of the later Roman Empire would have recognized these texts as forming a genre, or whether they would have called this genre 'ekphrasis?' If the term is being used as a purely abstract tool to focus reflection, the answer may be 'no.' But the moment questions of literary history enter the picture, as they do in almost all studies of 'ekphrasis,' terminology surely does matter. Few literary historians would deny that knowledge of how a genre was defined in a particular period is important if we want to gain some understanding of the production and reception of texts. Philostratos' *Imagines*, for example, take on a

9 – For example, N. Land, *The Viewer as Poet: The Renaissance Response to Art* (University Park, 1994), p. xvi.

10 – Roland Barthes, 'L'effet de réel', in *Littérature et réalité*, ed. R. Barthes *et al.* (Paris, 1982), p. 84; S. Rabau, 'Narration et description: l'exigence de détails', *Lalies*, xv (1995), pp. 273–89.

11 – George Kennedy, *A New History of Classical Rhetoric* (Princeton, 1994), p. 206: 'The subjects [of *ekphrasis*] . . . may be persons, actions, times, places, animals, and growing things. . . . *Ekphrasis* is an important feature of classical literature, beginning with the Shield of Achilles.' P. DuBois, *History, Rhetorical Description and the Epic from Homer to Spenser* (Cambridge, 1982), p. 4 performs a similar manoeuvre when she states that 'the description in words of a work of plastic art, the *ekphrasis* was one of the *progymnasmata*.'

12 – Scott, *Sculpted Word*, p. 1.

different hue when viewed against the background of rhetorical *ekphrasis* in all the breadth of the ancient definition, rather than being considered as members of a genre devoted to the description and/or interpretation of works of art. In the next section I will try to outline what the ancient definition of *ekphrasis* was and how the *Imagines* might be understood as an an example of *ekphrasis* in this sense. *Ekphrasis* as defined in antiquity emerges as a type of discourse that differs radically from the 'description of a work of art' we have come to expect, but the ancient rhetoricians' discussions nevertheless raise questions about the interaction of word and image, text and imagination.

So there is more than just philological correctness at stake in the definition of 'ekphrasis.' The lure of the modern meaning has too often obscured the ancient meaning, which is worthy of study in its own right. Definitions are also of crucial importance if one is to gain an accurate picture of tradition and continuity. It is one thing to borrow an ancient term (like 'ekphrasis' or, to take an example from another domain, 'democracy') and endow it with an altered meaning. It is quite another to assume that the shared name is a sign, or proof, of real historical continuity. Svetlana Alpers suggested in her seminal article that Giorgio Vasari was following a 'rhetorical tradition of *ekphrasis*' and was consciously placing himself in that tradition in his own writings.[13] This claim has been hugely influential, despite the fact that Alpers adduces very little evidence beyond Vasari's supposed familiarity with Philostratos and Lucian. Her argument rests on the power and ambiguity of the term 'ekphrasis'. But terminology does not constitute history. As an obscure Greek rhetorical term it was, in fact, hardly known to Renaissance scholars and the few who did know it used it in the broader ancient sense which it had in Byzantine Greek. The only 'rhetorical tradition of ekphrasis' which a writer of Vasari's period could have known as such was one which encompassed descriptions of all kinds of subjects and was not confined to works of art. The extent and nature of Vasari's use of individual classical models is a complex question which is only obscured by the assumption that he conceived of his writings within a unified classical tradition of writing on art.[14] The projection of the modern meaning of 'ekphrasis' back to the Renaissance serves to facilitate this assumption and to mask what is particular about Vasari's enterprise. The modern critic may now wish to categorise Vasari's descriptions alongside those of Lucian or Philostratos for the purpose of comparison or contrast, but this does not mean that these works formed any sort of continuous tradition, a nuance which is obscured by giving them all the ancient label 'ekphrasis'.

On a more basic level, it is important, especially given the wide range of possible meanings of *ekphrasis*, to know precisely how the term is being used each time it is encountered. Clearly, ancient rhetoricians did not mean 'description of a work of art' when they used the term, but what about later writers? When the anonymous author of the 1814 *Edinburgh Review* article cited in the *Oxford English Dictionary* and discussed by Grant Scott referred to 'florid effeminacies of style . . . in a love-letter of Philostratus, or an ecphrasis of Libanius', can one be sure that the modern sense of 'description of a work of art' was in his mind?[15] Or was he using

13 – Svetlana Alpers, 'Ekphrasis and aesthetic attitudes in Vasari's *Lives*', *Journal of the Warburg and Courtauld Institutes*, XXIII (1960), pp. 190–215.

14 – Patricia Rubin, *Giorgio Vasari: Art and History* (New Haven and London, 1995), pp. 275–6.

15 – Scott, *Sculpted Word*, chapter I; *idem*, 'The Rhetoric of Dilation: *ekphrasis* and ideology', *Word & Image*, VII (1991), pp. 301–10, discussing the review of H. S. Boyd, *Select Passages of the Writings of St Chrysostom, St Gregory Nazianzen, and St Basil* (London, 1813), *The Edinburgh Review* (1814), pp. 59–72.

the term in something closer to the ancient sense, in which case the quotation is only tangentially relevant to the relationship between art and literature (though highly revealing of nineteenth-century attitudes towards rhetoric and description)? The more likely answer is the latter, for the modern, specialized definition of *ekphrasis* turns out on further inspection to be far more modern than is usually assumed. The restriction to 'descriptions of *objets d'art*' dates not to late antiquity (the broad ancient definition was still familiar to Byzantine writers), nor even to the Renaissance (when the term was used as a translation of *descriptio*, or copied directly from Byzantine sources, when it was used at all), but as far as I have been able to trace its development only to the mid-twentieth century.

First of all, the absence of the term from the type of context in which one would now expect to find it is striking. Gotthold E. Lessing, for example, did not use the term in the *Laokoön*, the discussion of the relationship of poetry to painting in which the Shield of Achilles, now considered the grandmother of all *ekphraseis*, features prominently. Even Paul Friedländer, who is generally credited with having compiled the first and most thorough survey of *ekphrasis* in ancient and Byzantine literature in 1912, does not use the term in its modern sense.[16] 'Ekphrasis' does occur in the lengthy Introduction to two early Byzantine *ekphraseis* of monuments, but it is used strictly in accordance with ancient practice, when discussing a group of texts which, like the Philostratean *Imagines*, were rhetorical *ekphraseis* whose subject-matter was a work of art and which therefore fell into the range of his survey. As the title of his study indicates, 'Kunstbeschreibung' is used to designate what critics now know as 'ekphrasis'. What Friedländer achieved was certainly to define the group of texts that would come to be known as examples of *ekphrasis* in classical literature. He shaped conceptions of the 'genre' *ekphrasis* without giving it a name. But it was not until the 1950s, with the work of Leo Spitzer and Jean Hagstrum and, in the domain of archaeology, the entry by Glanville Downey in the *Reallexikon für Antike und Christentum*, that the term came to the attention of a wide scholarly audience and acquired the first versions of its restricted meaning which has since undergone an endless process of revision and refinement.[17]

16 – P. Friedländer, *Johannes von Gaza und Paulus Silentarius: Kunstbeschreibungen Justinianischer Zeit* (Leipzig and Berlin, 1912).

It was the prodigiously learned and inventive Spitzer who, in 1955, coined the definition which most people now recognise ('*ekphrasis*, the poetic description of a pictorial or sculptural work of art') and ensured that Keats' Urn would stand alongside the Shield of Achilles as one of the defining members of the new genre.[18] Until then, with a few notable exceptions, the term had been largely confined to works of philology, along with other obscure late Greek rhetorical terms, and led a shadowy existence in the half-light of the academic footnote, rarely honoured by transliteration into the Roman alphabet.

17 – Leo Spitzer, 'The "Ode on a Grecian Urn," or content vs. metagrammar', in *Essays on English and American Literature*, ed. A. Hatcher (Princeton, 1962), pp. 67–97; originally published in *Comparative Literature*, VII (1955); Hagstrum, *The Sister Arts*; Glanville Downey, 'Ekphrasis', in *Reallexikon für Antike und Christentum*, vol. 4 (Stuttgart, 1959), pp. 921–44.

18 – Spitzer, 'The "Ode on a Grecian Urn"', p. 72. W. T. J. Mitchell, *Iconology: Image, Text, Ideology* (Chicago, 1985), p. 99, refers to the Ode as 'the ritual example' of ekphrastic poetry.

Of course Spitzer did not invent this new meaning in a vacuum. His coinage gained currency because the ideas it expressed were increasingly of interest and Friedländer's survey is itself one of the signs of this interest. So the story of how the term 'ekphrasis' made the transition from these dusty origins to the glamorous world of critical theory is a significant chapter in the history of ideas. It was the result of converging interests in the 'description of works of art' in a range of disciplines,

from archaeology to English literature — a diversity which perhaps helps to explain the variety of shades of meaning of the single term 'ekphrasis' in modern criticism. I will trace this story in the second half of this article. First, however, I would like to explore the meaning of 'ekphrasis' in its original context, the rhetorical tradition of the first centuries CE.

Ancient *ekphrasis*

The ancient scholia to Homer give a good impression of the range of passages which could be classified as *ekphrasis* in antiquity. The account of the Shield of Achilles, and other sets of armour, are referred to as *ekphraseis*, but so is the descent of Apollo (likened to that of a hawk; *Iliad*, 15, 237–8) and the account of Achilles sinking exhausted into sleep beside the funeral pyre of Patroklos (*Iliad*, 23, 232).[19] An even greater range of examples is in the *Progymnasmata*, elementary exercises used to train students in the basic skills needed to compose speeches (or indeed any other kind of text). The composition of an *ekphrasis* is one of the more advanced exercises following exercises in, among other things, narration, confirmation and refutation of a version of events, praise and blame, comparison and characterization. The definition of *ekphrasis* provided by the various versions of the *Progymnasmata* is practically identical. Theon (first century CE), 'Hermogenes' (possibly second century CE), Aphthonios (fourth century CE) and Nikolaos (fifth century CE) all define it as: 'a speech which leads one around (*periegematikos*), bringing the subject matter vividly (*enargos*) before the eyes.'[20] The authors all then go on to suggest the range of subject-matter proper to *ekphrasis*. The earliest of them, Theon, suggests persons (*prosopa*), places (*topoi*), times (*chronoi*) and events (*pragmata*). This list remains standard throughout, although it undergoes various emendations: Aphthonios adds plants and animals, while Nikolaos adds festivals, belatedly reflecting the dominance of epideictic oratory of celebration and display over the judicial oratory of the courtroom under the Roman Empire.

The contrast with the modern definitions is clear, works of art as a category are of no particular importance. Nikolaos does go on later in his discussion of *ekphrasis* to give some instructions for 'when we describe statues or paintings or anything of this sort' but these are not included in his main list of subjects.[21] And when Theon refers to the Shield of Achilles it is under the idiosyncratic heading, which he is the only one to mention, of *ekphraseis* of the *tropos*, the manner in which something is done. What interests him about the Shield is the same quality praised by Lessing, the narrative unfolding of the making of the shield by Hephaistos, its status as a description not of an object but of a process. Theon, moreover, does not classify the shield as art, but places it instead alongside other descriptions of the preparation of military equipment. We need not place too much emphasis on this aspect of Theon's classification system, but it is a useful reminder that categories like 'work of art' are neither universal nor immutable.

The most interesting aspect of the *progymnasmata*, though, is not the absence of works of art (in itself a relatively minor detail), but the way in which the authors define *ekphrasis* first and foremost as a type of speech (*logos*) that has a certain effect upon an audience. An *ekphrasis* appeals to

19 – *Scholia Graeca in Homeri Iliadem*, ed. H. Erbse, vol. 4 (Berlin, 1975), p. 64; vol. 5 (Berlin, 1977), p. 404.

20 – Theon, *Progymnasmata*, ed. M. Patillon (Paris, 1997), pp. 66–9 (with French translation); Hermogenes, *Opera*, ed. H. Rabe (Leipzig, 1913), p. 22; Aphthonios, *Progymnasmata*, ed. H. Rabe (Leipzig, 1926), p. 36; Nikolaos, *Progymnasmata*, ed. J. Felten (Leipzig, 1913), p. 68. The only difference in terminology is that Nikolaos has *aphegematikos* (from *aphegema* 'a telling, a tale') instead of *periegematikos*. I have preserved the root meaning of the latter term in the translation rather than translating 'descriptive'. For more discussion of the possible senses, see Theon, *Progymnasmata*, p. 149, n. 323.

21 – Nikolaos, *Progymnasmata*, p. 69.

the mind's eye of the listener, making him or her 'see' the subject-matter, whatever it may be. The nature of the subject-matter is of secondary importance. One cannot help but be struck by the contrast with the terms in which description in general (not to mention *ekphrasis* in particular) is defined in modern textbooks. It is the subject-matter that commonly defines a description and which distinguishes it from narration: a description deals with objects, while narration deals with actions.[22] *Ekphrasis* in contrast was defined in terms of its impact on an audience.

22 – M. Bal, *Narratology* (Toronto, 1985), p. 130.

So the very basis on which the definition is built distinguishes *ekphrasis* from the concept of description familiar from modern narratology. There are further radical differences that suggest that the way ancient writers conceived of *ekphrasis* was very different from the way in which we conceive of either description or *ekphrasis* in the sense of 'description of an art object.' Among Theon's list of subjects is *pragmata*, 'things done,' 'actions.' That 'actions' or 'events,' rather than 'objects' (as it is sometimes translated), is the sense of the Greek term, *pragmata*, is clear from the examples cited by all the authors: battles. What is more, such *ekphraseis* should progress from an account of what preceded the battle to the event itself, and then to its aftermath.[23] This means that the fundamental distinction between narration (unfolding in time) and description (the problematic verbal representation of an object, constituting a 'narrative pause') upon which so much modern theory of description and its interpretation is based, is disregarded by the ancient theoreticians.[24]

23 – For example, Theon, *Progymnasmata*, p. 68.

24 – Rabau, 'Narration et description'.

The modern assumption that objects are the proper domain of description has influenced the way in which *ekphrasis* is often defined as a description of an 'art object,' a definition which it is now clear differs in spirit as well as in the letter from the ancient one. Barthes' treatment of ancient ekphrasis in 'L'effet du reel' illustrates how problematic the category of *pragmata* is for a critic who wishes to assimilate the rhetorical definition of *ekphrasis* to modern critical theories of description. The account of *ekphrasis* as defined in ancient rhetoric is accurate except for one detail: Barthes quietly omits the category of actions or events (replacing it with the category 'works of art' to bring ancient *ekphrasis* in line with the modern definition).[25] The manoeuvre is scarcely detectable, but it changes the nature of *ekphrasis*, limiting its subject-matter to the static, the objectified and, of course, associating it with the work of art.

25 – Barthes, 'L'effet du réel', p. 84: '*ekphrasis* . . . avait pour objet de décrire des lieux, des temps, des personnes ou des oeuvres d'art . . ..'

Barthes' free emendation of his ancient sources implies that the range of subjects suggested by the *progymnasmata* is nothing more than a random selection that can be manipulated at will with no effect on the whole. But this is not the case. The four types of subject-matter that remain standard throughout the tradition from Theon to Nikolaos, persons, places, times and events, formed a coherent set in the ancient rhetorical system. They represent four of the six parts of narration (or *peristaseis*), corresponding to who? (the agent), what? (the act) and when and where? (time and place). Missing are the cause (why?), which is rarely amenable to being 'placed before the eyes,' and the manner in which the act was committed (how?). This last part of narration is included by Theon, and was the category in which he placed the Shield of Achilles, but is not found listed as a category elsewhere, although Nikolaos does explain how it might be included in an *ekphrasis*.

So not only is ekphrasis not conceived as a form of writing dedicated to the 'art object,' but also it is not even restricted to objects. It is a form of vivid evocation that may have as its subject-matter anything — an action, a person, a place, a battle, even a crocodile. What distinguishes *ekphrasis* is its quality of vividness, *enargeia*, its impact on the mind's eye of the listener who must, in Theon's words, be almost made to see the subject.[26] Nikolaos, the latest of the authors, gives the clearest account of the relation of *ekphrasis* to narration in the ancient rhetorical system. Narration is a simple account of what happened, while an *ekphrasis* includes the details that tell one *how* it happened, how it looked (one might add also how it sounded and felt).[27] The difference, in Nikolaos' terms, is *enargeia*, vividness, an *ekphrasis* in sum is a vivid form of narration. As well as taking us to the heart of the ancient definition of *ekphrasis*, Nikolaos' comment reveals the meaning of the '*ek*' in *ekphrasis*: it serves to indicate fullness, thoroughness. To compose an *ekphrasis* is to tell (*phrazo*) in full (*ek*).

Enargeia is at the heart of *ekphrasis*.[28] The *Progymnasmata* give no explanation of this quality of language, obviously assuming prior knowledge in their readers, but other more elaborate treatises do provide some explanations. Quintilian explains both how to produce *enargeia* in a speech and what its effect upon the listener should be. In the *Institutio oratoria* (6.2.29–32) he explains that *enargeia* is produced when the orator uses his own power of imagination to conjure up a scene in his mind. This exercise in visualization ensures that his language will spark a mental impression in the mind of his audience. The function of this is made clear later on in the work (8.3.62). A successful orator must move his audience, must make them feel as if they were present at the events described, this is the purpose of *enargeia*.

Quintilian is imprecise about the mechanics of this process, preferring to demonstrate with his own examples, or to describe his personal response to *enargeia* in Cicero (*Institutio oratoria*, 8.3.64). But his ideas do find resonance in ancient theories of memory, imagination and language. The images impressed on the mind by sense experience linger as memory to be manipulated as part of memory techniques, in each act of recollection or even as the basis of thought itself.[29] Language, particularly for Quintilian language which has the quality of *enargeia*, is produced by such images (in the mind of the speaker) and gives rise to other, comparable, images in the listener's mind. It is difficult for us, with our concept of a free and creative imagination, to understand how a speaker could be sure of working the right effect. But the imagination to which vivid language was thought to appeal was more a store-house of images derived from sense perception and informed by a common culture. To be sure of the effect of his speech a speaker needed to ensure that his subject-matter conformed to his audience's expectations and prior knowledge. It was more important that the events communicated by the orator should be 'like truth,' that they should be acceptable to the listener, than that they should actually have happened.[30]

Several of the passages Quintilian cites as examples of *enargeia* are directly paralled in the Greek discussions of *ekphrasis* in the *progymnasmata* and in more advanced manuals. From this combination of ancient sources one can arrive at some understanding of what ancient rhetoricians meant

26 – Theon, *Progymnasmata*, p. 69.

27 – Nikolaos, *Progymnasmata*, pp. 68–9.

28 – F. Graf, 'Ekphrasis: Die Enstellung der Gattung in der Antike', in *Beschreibungskunst-Kunstbrescheibung*, eds. G. Boehm and H. Pfotenhauer (Munich, 1995), pp. 143–55.

29 – R. Webb, 'Imagination and the arousal of the emotions', in *The Passions in Roman Literature and Thought*, eds. S. Braund and C. Gill (Cambridge, 1997), pp. 112–27; *idem*, 'Mémoire et imagination: les limites de l'*enargeia*', in *Dire l'évidence*, eds. C. Lévy and L. Pernot (Paris, 1997), pp. 229–48.

30 – Quintilian, *Institutio oratoria*, 6.2.30.

by *ekphrasis* and its function. *Ekphrasis* was an evocation of a scene, often a scene unfolding in time like a battle, a murder or the sack of a city. The impact derived from the judicious choice of details that corresponded to the audience's prior knowledge and expectations, calling up the mental images already stocked in the store-house of memory. Such passages, far from constituting 'narrative pauses' (and consequently demanding interpretation) were often an intensification of the narrative, introducing a degree of detail which would involve the audience both imaginatively and emotionally. And far from being independent, detachable passages, *ekphraseis* could contribute to the persuasive effect of the whole.

This seems to be the ideal reflected by the various rhetorical authors. In practice the isolation of *ekphrasis* as an independent school exercise does seem to have encouraged both the composition of free-standing *ekphraseis*, like the *Imagines*, and in some cases a sterile proliferation of detail at the expense of *enargeia*.[31] Works of art, as Nikolaos acknowledges, provided subjects, but *ekphrasis* was never associated solely with these. It is interesting then to consider Philostratos' *Imagines* as *ekphrasis* in this ancient rhetorical sense, the sense in which the Younger Philostratos presumably used the word when he described his grandfather's work as '*ekphraseis* of works of graphic art' in the Proem to his own *Imagines*. One feature of Philostratos' paintings that has provoked much comment is the way in which the descriptions often do not define a single moment which might have been depicted in the static medium of painting. For the nineteenth-century German scholars who hotly debated the existence of the gallery this was yet one more example of Philostratos' failure to make his language submit dutifully to its subject. But, if *ekphrasis* is a form of vivid narration, Philostratos' narrative presentation of his various subjects is only to be expected. Another objection raised by these German scholars was that many of the subjects derived directly from the poets.[32] What Philostratos' reliance on the poets suggests though, is that the 'paintings' reflect a common stock of themes, familiar from texts, the arts and, in some cases, the stage, which would therefore be already stored in his audience's memories. Philostratos' images would then be the result of a sophisticated interplay between remembered texts and images, painted on the canvas of the listener's mind.

This discussion of the subject-matter of the *Imagines* serves to highlight the special nature of *ekphraseis* of the visual arts. Even when speakers are evoking works that, as far as one can tell, really existed, it is above all the subject-matter contained in the frame that they seek to 'bring before the eyes.' In the case of ancient and Byzantine art this subject-matter was familiar, often repeated and represented in both word and image. Such narratives had a cultural significance far greater than that of any single artistic representation. In the case of real works of art it is not surprising, therefore, that attention should be focussed on the narrative depicted. In the case of fictional works (or works of dubious status), like those in Philostratos' gallery, the frame of the painting may function in other ways as well: as a pretext for bringing together *ekphraseis* of such a variety of subjects, and as a metaphor, signalling the intended effect of such graphic descriptions. *Enargeia* easily suggested to ancient critics an analogy with painting. It is easy to forget that Simonides' often-quoted dictum that

31 – For example, the model *ekphraseis* of statues attributed variously to Nikolaos and to Libanios, in Libanios, *Opera*, ed. R. Foerster, Vol. 8 (Leipzig, 1915), pp. 491–540.

32 – For a summary of the arguments, see Philostratos, *Die Bilder*, ed. O. Schönberger (Munich, 1968), pp. 26–37. For a more positive assessment of Philostratos' use of the poets, see M. Blanchard, 'Problèmes du texte et du tableau: les limites de l'imitation à l'époque hellénistique et sous l'empire', in *Le Plaisir de parler: études de sophistique comparée*, ed. B. Cassin (Paris, 1986), pp. 131–54.

'painting is mute poetry and poetry speaking painting' is quoted by Plutarch to illustrate a discussion of *enargeia*. Plutarch's interest was in the second comparison, in the ability of a text (more precisely historical narrative) to represent as vividly as painting, in the quality of *enargeia* in Thucydides' history writing.[33]

33 – Plutarch, *Moralia*, 346–7.

Such a brief analysis cannot begin to do justice to the complexity of Philostratos' enterprise, but I hope that it suggests how the ancient rhetorical background might shed a different light on this text. Philostratos' work is an important example of an ancient *ekphrasis* that has works of art as its subject and which therefore stands at the intersection of the ancient and modern definitions of the term. The modern reception of the *Imagines* also illustrates the problems encountered by later generations of readers in allocating this text to a recognizable genre and in reconciling it with modern expectations of 'description'. The German debates of the nineteenth century were sparked by Philostratos' manifest failure to provide the type of information expected of a 'true description' by scholars of that period. Philostratos is also key to the development of the new definition of 'ekphrasis' for it was in response to questions such as these that attention first began to be turned to the meaning of the term.

The invention of a genre

Editors of Philostratos in the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries had already noted that the Younger Philostratos referred to his grandfather's *Imagines* as '*ekphraseis* of works of graphic art' and that the term was also the title given to a collection of descriptions of statues by Kallistratos. But it was in the middle of the nineteenth century that the term became a subject of serious investigation. In 1867 Friedrich Matz published a Latin treatise, *De Philostratorum in describendis imaginibus fide*, in which he argued that an understanding of the genre to which the text belonged was crucial to the debate on the author's reliability as a source. He discussed various examples of description of works of art in the Second Sophistic, placing Philostratos alongside Lucian, Apuleius and the Greek novels, and attributed this interest in art to the spirit of an age in which art and rhetoric flourished side by side. Matz concluded that though there may be grains of truth in the descriptions, Philostratos, like any writer of his period, inevitably introduced rhetorical embellishments.[34] Matz's enterprise — the removal of deceitful rhetoric to reveal the pearl of truth — reflects his own age and archaeological interests, but his work is still of interest because of its attention to questions of genre and the attempt to understand the intellectual climate of Philostratos' period. 'Ekphrasis' appears only a few times, in his account of the rhetorical background to the *Imagines*, and Matz seems not to have taken a special interest in the term. But this was the beginning of a long association of 'ekphrasis' with debates about descriptions of works of art. The *idea* of *ekphrasis* as a special kind of description of art objects was already coming to be separated from the wider ancient definition.

34 – Friedrich Matz, *De Philostratorum in describendis imaginibus fide* (Bonn, 1867), p. 45.

This focus on *ekphraseis* of paintings and the consequent detachment of these from the wider context of ancient *ekphrasis* was continued in the work of two French scholars, writing in the 1880s: E. Bertrand and A. Bougot. In reaction to the positivist agenda of the German school, they proposed

a reading of the *Imagines* as art criticism rather than reportage. Bertrand, whose account is enlivened by a highly imaginative account of the Elder Philostratos' state of mind on the day on which he 'invented art criticism,' echoed Matz's interest in the genre of Philostratos' text and the spirit of his age.[35] Bertrand took a crucial further step when he grouped Philostratos not just with other writers of the Second Sophistic but also with Catullus and Virgil, and identified these works as members of 'a fashionable genre which has its own name.'[36] The name is, of course, 'ekphrasis'. But Bertrand was curiously reluctant to display his find. He relegated it, untransliterated, to a footnote as if he were not wholly confident in his new use of the term. Bougot, however, showed no such reticence and used the term directly in his text, extending its range still further to include passages in Greek tragedy.[37]

35 – E. Bertrand, *Un Critique d'art dans l'antiquité: Philostrate et son école* (Paris, 1881), pp. 53–4.

36 – Ibid., p. 49.

37 – A. Bougot, *Philostrate l'Ancien: une galérie antique* (Paris, 1881), p. 172.

The nineteenth-century focus on Philostratos and his gallery came to highlight and gradually alter the meaning of *ekphrasis* from a specific type of description, which may include works of art, to a description of any type which has a work of art as its subject-matter. Simultaneously Philostratos' text was detached from its immediate cultural context and placed in a diachronic selection of 'descriptions of works of art' which were grouped together regardless of differences in genre and technique. This is not to say that Bertrand and Bougot were indifferent to the cultural context of the *Imagines*. On the contrary, Bertrand in particular tried to evoke Philostratos' world, once more developing an idea first proposed by Matz. The world Bertrand depicted was one in which art and literature flourished simultaneously and where poets were constantly drawn to the visual arts. This is an image in which the intellectual ideals of late nineteenth-century France have been superimposed onto the later Roman Empire. In particular, the influence of Théophile Gautier, whose own poem *l'Art* (1857) explores the equivalence of verbal and sculptural artistry, is clearly discernable. Bertrand's ancient sophist seems to be living the ideal of 'l'art pour l'art.' Bertrand and Bougot's redefinitions of 'ekphrasis' reflect this contemporary interest in the common ground between art and literature, and interart comparisons.

Bertrand and Bougot redefined the meaning of *ekphrasis* in response to their own intellectual world, in reaction to the positivism of the German archaeologists and encouraged by contemporary interests in the adaptations of techniques from one art into another (aptly termed 'transpositions d'art' by Huysmans in *L'Art moderne* of 1883). But their focus remained fixed on classical texts. This is true too of later French scholars like H. Piot and J. Bompaire who, in their treatments of *ekphrasis* in writings of the Second Sophistic, were careful to note the range of the ancient definition but chose to focus on descriptions of art and architecture because of the inherent interest they saw in these particular *ekphraseis*. Though writing in the second decade of the twentieth century, Piot was as thoroughly imbued with the spirit of Gautier as Bertrand had been. His analysis of the ancient sophists' 'taste for poetic vocabulary and artistic sentence structure which led them to cultivate that most sculptural of genres, ekphrasis,' reads like a paraphrase of Gautier's *l'Art* and is capped by a reference to 'transpositions d'art.'[38] But 'ekphrasis' was still more or less confined to the fields of classical and Byzantine art and literature until Spitzer's study of Keats'

38 – H. Piot, *Les procédés littéraires de la Second Sophistique chez Lucien: L'ecphrasis* (Rennes, 1914), p. 22; J. Bompaire, *Lucien écrivain: imatation et création* (Paris, 1958), p. 707.

'Ode' catapulted it into the world of English and Comparative literature. Spitzers' definition deserves to be quoted at length:

> it [the *Ode*] belongs to the genre, known to Occidental literature from Homer and Theocritus to the Parnassians and Rilke, of the *ekphrasis*, the poetic description of a pictorial or sculptural work of art, which description implies, in the words of Theophile Gautier, 'une transposition d'art,' the reproduction, through the medium of words, of sensuously perceptible *objets d'art* ('ut pictura poesis').[39]

39 – Spitzer, 'The "Ode on a Grecian Urn"', p. 72.

Reading this confident statement one would hardly guess that it represented such a radical redefinition. *Ekphrasis* was now entirely divorced from its rhetorical background and reinterpreted as a poetic genre stretching not only backwards to Homer and Theocritus, but also forward to the nineteenth century. This article was not the first in which Spitzer had discussed poems on works of art, but previously the term 'ekphrasis' had hardly appeared. It is used once, in Greek and buried in a footnote, in an article on Garcilaso de la Vega's description of a tapestry which, in its evocation of light and shade embodied the 'transpositions d'art' which fascinated Spitzer too.[40] Spitzer's use of the term in the Keats article was new to his own œuvre and it is unlikely that he was unaware of the originality of the step he was taking. His distaste for footnotes and tendency to misattribute quotations (as with 'transpositions d'art' above) make it difficult to trace his sources for his definition of *ekphrasis*. But the examples he uses – including the Parnassians and Gautier – make his intellectual affiliations clear. And once again the redefinition of *ekphrasis* takes place in response to existing interests. Spitzer's article fell on fertile ground, already prepared by the New Critics' interest in the poem as artifact, an idea in search of a name.

40 – L. Spitzer, 'Garcilaso, Third Eclogue, lines 265–271', *Hispanic Review*, XX (1952) p. 248, n. 5. I am grateful to Alejandro Coroleu for drawing my attention to this article. The term does not appear at all in an earlier study of an art object by Spitzer, 'Wiederum Mörikes Gedicht "Auf eine Lampe"', *Trivium*, IX (1951), pp. 203–25.

Now, the term had been thoroughly removed from its ancient meaning and context. Instead of designating a dynamic mode of writing thought to have an immediate impact on its audience and whose range of subject-matter could include images of action and movement, 'ekphrasis' came to be used of a work of literature in which the movement was found only in the flow of language, whose subject-matter was still, objectified, making the poem itself an object of detached interpretation rather than an active stimulus to imaginative involvement.

Conclusion

Throughout the nineteenth and twentieth centuries 'ekphrasis' has undergone a process of gradual redefinition to conform to contemporary intellectual and esthetic preoccupations. This process, which it has only been possible to sketch here, helps to explain the diversity of the modern definitions of the term. In the absence of an agreed definition, apart from the broadest 'writing on art,' each critic is able, effectively, to redefine the term to suit his or her interests and to fit the corpus of works chosen as representative. Definitions of *ekphrasis* are thus in danger of becoming (like Keats' urn) circular.

One response might be to invent a range of new terms, like Peter Wagner's 'intermediality', to correspond to the range of connotations currently attached to 'ekphrasis.'[41] I would welcome such a move, as

41 – Peter Wagner, 'Introduction: Ekphrasis, Iconotexts, and Intermediality — the State(s) of the Art(s)', in Wagner (ed.), *Icons — Texts — Iconotexts*, pp. 1–40.

someone whose main field of interest is the ancient sense and context of the term. But there would be wider advantages in removing the illusion of antiquity from what is essentially a modern coinage. For however divergent the modern definitions of *ekphrasis* are on the surface, they all have in common the fact that they are modern and are predicated directly or indirectly on a certain set of assumptions about description in particular and about texts in general: the perceived dichotomy between description and narration; the association of description with the passive object; a conception of literature as a text to be treated as an object of study rather than as a transcription of oral performance which, even in its written form, can work a powerful effect upon a reader. In denying the possibility of a verbal representation of reality, poststructuralist reactions to positivist ideals of 'realistic' or 'truthful' description still preserve the dichotomy between object and action and still, ironically yet inevitably, focus on the absent 'reality.' From this perspective, Barthes' account of *ekphrasis* as a 'detachable fragment, an end in itself' is not so far away from the 'art for art's sake' of the previous century.

Ekphrasis as defined in the ancient rhetorical sources is based on a different set of assumptions that are as far removed from naive realism as they are from the coldly analytical formulae of a critic like Philippe Hamon.[42] The rhetoricians speak freely of the psychological impact of the word and the imaginative contribution of the listener. Yet theirs is an imagination bounded by cultural tradition, by the collective memory of an educated élite. Verbal representation thus aims only at verisimilitude, an impression of truth, and seeks only to evoke a relatively restricted range of culturally significant images. Ancient discussions of verbal representation — *enargeia*, *hypotyposis*, *ekphrasis* — thus side-step the problem of whether language can or should represent reality by assuming that words appeal instead to the mental impressions left by perception.

42 – Philippe Hamon, *Du descriptif* (Paris, 1993).

This interpretation of *ekphrasis* is far away from Keats' Urn. But although it raises some rather different issues from those usually associated with the term — mental images rather than works of art, word as dynamic force rather than object or tool of interpretation — it deserves attention in its own right if only because it reminds one of the profound differences between our ways of thinking about such questions and those current in antiquity, differences which are only obscured by the invented tradition of a genre of *ekphrasis* spanning Western literature from Homer to Keats and beyond.